

Language Play and Comic Identity: Nigerian Pidgin in *Jenifa's Diary*

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Abstract

Nigerian Pidgin English occupies a central position in Nigerian television comedy, particularly within sitcoms that rely on everyday speech to generate humour and negotiate social meaning. While existing scholarship on Jenifa's Diary has examined humour strategies, stereotypes, and pragmatic functions, little attention has been paid to Nigerian Pidgin as the primary linguistic engine through which humour and identity are jointly produced, nor has humour theory been systematically integrated with identity theory in analysing the series. Addressing this gap, this study examines how Nigerian Pidgin functions as a humour-generating and identity-shaping linguistic system in Jenifa's Diary. The analysis is anchored in Disparagement Humour Theory and Social Identity Theory, which together illuminate how ridicule, exaggeration, and linguistic play produce laughter while constructing in-group and out-group distinctions. Using a qualitative case study design, the study conducts interpretative content analysis of two purposively selected episodes—"HIV Status" (Season 11, Episode 4) and "Fake Life" (Season 21, Episode 1). Findings show that humour is generated through malapropism, phonological distortion, code-switching, and embodied performance, with Nigerian Pidgin functioning as a marker of authenticity, intimacy, and emotional expression. While "HIV Status" mobilises linguistic confusion to address health anxiety and misinformation, "Fake Life" deploys ridicule to expose aspirational pretence and digital performance culture. The study contributes to linguistic, sociocultural, media, and theoretical scholarship by foregrounding Nigerian Pidgin as a central comic resource and demonstrating the value of integrating humour and identity theories in analysing Nigerian television comedy.

Keywords: *Nigerian Pidgin English, television comedy, linguistic humour, social identity, disparagement humour, Nigerian sitcoms, popular culture.*

Introduction

Humour occupies a central place in Nigerian popular culture, functioning not merely as entertainment but as a socially embedded practice through which individuals and communities negotiate everyday realities, anxieties, and aspirations. Nigerian comedy in its various

forms—stand-up performances, televised sitcoms, and comedic sketches—serves as a vehicle for social critique and cultural commentary, often reflecting and reshaping public attitudes toward political, economic, and social issues (Adebisi, 2023). Within Nigerian television culture, the situation comedy (sitcom) has emerged as one of the most influential genres for the circulation of humour, relying on recurring characters, familiar settings, and everyday encounters to generate laughter while engaging audiences with societal concerns. Sitcom humour is fundamentally language-driven, depending on dialogue, exaggeration, repetition, and performative delivery, which makes linguistic choice central to comic effect. In the Nigerian context, this linguistic creativity is deeply shaped by multilingualism, with Nigerian Pidgin English emerging as one of the most productive resources for humour, identity performance, and social commentary in popular media.

Nigeria's linguistic landscape, characterised by the coexistence of English with hundreds of indigenous languages, provides fertile ground for linguistic play and hybrid expression. Nigerian Pidgin English (NPE), often dismissed in popular discourse as “Broken English,” is in fact a dynamic and rule-governed linguistic system that has evolved through processes of indigenisation shaped by local communicative needs (Mbisike, 2007, p. 29). Its accessibility, expressive flexibility, and rhythmic quality make it especially suited to comic performance. As Zabalbeascoa (1996, p. 253) observes, language-dependent humour—such as puns, malapropisms, phonological distortions, and semantic ambiguity—draws directly on the internal resources of language itself. Nigerian Pidgin readily lends itself to such humour strategies, enabling speakers and performers to exploit exaggeration, approximation, and creative deviation for comic effect. Beyond entertainment, Pidgin carries deep cultural resonance: it indexes intimacy, authenticity, and social belonging, while simultaneously reflecting sociolinguistic negotiations of class, power, and identity.

Within Nigerian popular media, Nigerian Pidgin functions not only as a comic code but also as a cultural signifier through which social hierarchies are both enacted and contested. Sen's (2012, p. 4) description of humour as a culturally embedded phenomenon is particularly relevant here, as Pidgin-based humour derives its meaning from shared social knowledge and lived experience. Its informal status, often contrasted with the prestige associated with Standard English, positions Nigerian Pidgin at the centre of ideological struggles over linguistic legitimacy. In comedic contexts, this tension becomes a source of humour, allowing performers to ridicule authority, expose pretence, and articulate everyday frustrations without direct confrontation.

A prominent site where Nigerian Pidgin is deployed with sustained comic and cultural effect is *Jenifa's Diary*, one of Nigeria's most influential and long-running television sitcoms created by Funke Akindele. The series revolves around the character Jenifa, whose exaggerated persona is defined largely through her distinctive linguistic repertoire, which blends Nigerian Pidgin, non-standard English, Yoruba-accented English, and frequent malapropisms. The humour of the series is driven primarily by language: through deliberate mispronunciations, code-switching, semantic distortions, and embodied performance, Jenifa's speech becomes the engine of comedy. Olawe (2020, p. 65) notes that these linguistic antics do more than amuse; they illuminate broader Nigerian attitudes toward language, education, class, and aspiration. As such, the sitcom offers a rich text for examining how humour operates through language to

construct character identity and engage social realities.

Despite the popularity of *Jenifa's Diary* and the growing body of scholarship it has attracted, existing studies have largely approached the series from limited linguistic angles. Scholars have examined syntactic deviation (Olawe, 2020), phonological features and accent (Faleye, 2022), representations of identity and social reality (John, 2020), and the use of Nigerian English deviations as humour resources (Bamigbola, 2022). While these studies provide valuable insights, they seldom foreground Nigerian Pidgin itself as the primary humour-generating mechanism of the sitcom. Moreover, there has been limited integration of humour theory with identity theory in analysing how linguistic humour in the series produces social meaning. Consequently, Nigerian Pidgin is often treated as a background code or stylistic feature rather than as a central analytical category through which humour, identity construction, and social critique intersect. This gap points to the need for a more focused and theoretically grounded examination of Nigerian Pidgin as a core comic and sociolinguistic resource in *Jenifa's Diary*.

This study responds to that gap by examining how Nigerian Pidgin functions as a humour-generating and identity-shaping linguistic system in *Jenifa's Diary*. Focusing on two purposively selected episodes—"HIV Status" (Season 11, Episode 4) and "Fake Life" (Season 21, Episode 1)—the study explores how Pidgin-based humour is mobilised in contrasting sociocultural contexts. While "HIV Status" employs linguistic misunderstanding and exaggeration to address fear, stigma, and health misinformation, "Fake Life" satirises class performance, digital self-fashioning, and aspirational lifestyles in contemporary Lagos. These episodes provide analytically rich contexts for observing how Nigerian Pidgin mediates humour, social meaning, and identity negotiation.

This study addresses the under-theorisation of Nigerian Pidgin English as a primary humour-generating system in Nigerian television sitcoms. While existing scholarship on *Jenifa's Diary* has examined syntactic deviation, accent, stereotypes, and pragmatic humour strategies, Nigerian Pidgin is often treated as a peripheral stylistic feature rather than as the central linguistic mechanism through which humour, identity, and social critique are produced. By foregrounding Nigerian Pidgin as the core comic resource of the series, this study contributes linguistically by advancing Pidgin-based humour analysis, socioculturally by linking linguistic comedy to issues of health anxiety, class aspiration, and digital self-fashioning, and within media studies by offering a focused sitcom analysis grounded in Nigerian television practice. Theoretically, the study demonstrates the value of integrating Disparagement Humour Theory and Social Identity Theory in analysing how popular comedy simultaneously entertains and negotiates identity, power, and belonging in postcolonial media contexts.

Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative case study design, employing interpretative content analysis to examine how Nigerian Pidgin English (NPE) functions as a humour-generating and identity-shaping linguistic resource in *Jenifa's Diary*. A qualitative approach is appropriate because humour is inherently contextual, relying on linguistic nuance, performance, shared cultural knowledge, and audience recognition rather than on quantifiable frequency patterns. As a case study, the research treats *Jenifa's Diary* as a bounded cultural text through which broader sociolinguistic processes—particularly the relationship between language, humour, and

identity in Nigerian popular media—can be closely examined.

From the sitcom's twenty-eight seasons, two episodes were purposively selected: “HIV Status” (Season 11, Episode 4) and “Fake Life” (Season 21, Episode 1). These episodes were chosen based on three criteria. First, they present a clear thematic contrast, with “HIV Status” centring on health panic, fear, and misinformation, while “Fake Life” focuses on aspirational culture, social media performance, and material pretence. Second, both episodes exhibit a high density of Nigerian Pidgin-based humour, including malapropisms, exaggerated speech, and strategic code-switching. Third, the episodes engage directly with socially relevant issues in contemporary Nigeria, making them suitable for analysing how humour mediates sociocultural meaning and identity negotiation.

Data collection involved repeated viewing of the selected episodes to ensure familiarity with narrative context, linguistic detail, and performance dynamics. Pidgin-heavy scenes were transcribed verbatim, with attention paid not only to spoken language but also to paralinguistic and non-verbal features such as intonation, gesture, facial expression, and exaggerated bodily movement, all of which contribute significantly to humour in the series. These annotations were necessary because humour in *Jenifa's Diary* is produced through the interaction of language and performance rather than through dialogue alone.

The analysis proceeded through thematic coding of the transcribed data. Coding categories included malapropism, code-switching, phonological distortion, and identity markers that signal class position, educational background, aspiration, or social belonging. The analytical process maintained a clear distinction between description and interpretation: descriptive analysis identified and illustrated specific linguistic and performative features that generate humour, while interpretative analysis examined how these features function within broader social, cultural, and theoretical contexts. This approach ensured that claims about humour, identity, and social commentary were grounded in textual evidence while remaining analytically driven rather than merely anecdotal.

Literature Review

Studies on *Jenifa's Diary*

Scholarly engagement with *Jenifa's Diary* has largely examined the sitcom as a site of humour, identity construction, and sociocultural critique, with particular emphasis on pragmatic strategies, stereotypes, and representational politics. Studies on humour strategies have demonstrated that comedy in the series serves functions beyond amusement. Sunday and Bamgbose (2021), drawing on Culpeper's Impoliteness Theory, identify teasing, parody, banter, retort, and put-downs as dominant humour strategies in *Jenifa's Diary* and *Professor JohnBull*, arguing that humour simultaneously amuses and castigates, reshaping interpersonal power relations. Similarly, Bamgbose and Ehondor (2012) show that humour in *Jenifa's Diary* performs pragmatic acts such as warning, advising, and enculturating, addressing social issues including domestic violence, incivility, and moral decline.

Other studies have foregrounded stereotypes and identity representation. Bamgbose and Ladele (2023) analyse ethnic and gender stereotypes in *Jenifa's Diary* and *Professor JohnBull*, revealing recurring typifications of the Yoruba as party-loving and the Igbo as commercially

driven, alongside portrayals of male dominance and female complicity in patriarchal structures. Ajayi (2018) similarly argues that Jenifa's grammatically "incorrect" speech functions ideologically, positioning the character as a voice for marginalised social groups while exposing inequalities embedded in everyday Nigerian life. Studies such as Ojomo and Adekusibe (2020) further situate Nigerian television sitcoms within broader debates on gender representation, noting how stereotypical portrayals reinforce social inequality.

Linguistic-focused studies have tended to isolate specific features rather than examine Nigerian Pidgin holistically. Olawe (2020) analyses syntactic deviations in Jenifa's speech, raising concerns about their implications for standard English usage among students, while Faleye (2022) focuses on phonological distortions and accent as humour-evoking devices. Bamigbola (2022) examines Nigerian English deviations as tools for humour, but without sustained attention to Nigerian Pidgin as an autonomous linguistic system. Although these studies offer valuable insights, they rarely foreground Nigerian Pidgin itself as the primary engine of humour, nor do they integrate humour theory with identity theory to explain how linguistic humour produces social meaning. This gap necessitates a focused investigation of Nigerian Pidgin as a central comic and identity-shaping resource in *Jenifa's Diary*.

Existing studies on *Jenifa's Diary* demonstrate sustained scholarly interest in humour strategies, identity representation, and sociocultural critique within the sitcom. However, these studies tend to isolate specific linguistic features—such as syntactic deviation, phonological distortion, or pragmatic humour—without theorising Nigerian Pidgin English as an integrated linguistic system that simultaneously generates humour and structures identity performance. Moreover, humour theory and identity theory are rarely brought into sustained dialogue in analysing the series. This study advances existing scholarship by foregrounding Nigerian Pidgin as the central humour-generating mechanism of the sitcom and by integrating Disparagement Humour Theory and Social Identity Theory to explain how linguistic humour both produces laughter and negotiates social belonging. In doing so, the study moves beyond descriptive accounts of humour to offer a theoretically grounded explanation of how Nigerian television comedy mediates identity, power, and social critique.

Nigerian Pidgin, Media, and Identity

Nigerian Pidgin English (NPE) has evolved into a widely spoken lingua franca that cuts across ethnic, regional, and class boundaries. Contrary to its popular dismissal as "broken English," scholars argue that NPE is a structured and rule-governed language shaped by prolonged contact between English and indigenous Nigerian languages (Elugbe & Omamor, 1991). Agheyisi (1984) notes that Pidgin carries strong symbolic value in Nigeria, functioning as a unifying code in a multilingual society. As an identity marker, NPE indexes authenticity, urban belonging, and cultural familiarity, often in contrast to Standard English, which is associated with institutional authority and elite status.

Language choice plays a central role in identity construction. Tajfel's (1985) work on social identity underscores how linguistic practices signal group membership and social categorisation, while Auer (2007) conceptualises language as a symbolic anchor of collective identity. In Nigerian popular culture, NPE operates as a medium through which speakers negotiate power, resistance, and belonging. Okunola (2024) demonstrates how Nigerian hip-

hop artists deploy Pidgin to resist linguistic imperialism and affirm national identity, while Ehondor (2020) highlights how the marginalisation of Pidgin in language policy perpetuates linguistic inequality. Within media texts, Nigerian Pidgin's accessibility and expressive range make it a potent tool for humour, satire, and social commentary, particularly in formats that rely on everyday speech and audience recognition.

Sitcom and Conversational Humour

Sitcoms are character-driven narratives structured around recurring situations, familiar settings, and cyclical storytelling. Dias Branco (2013) describes sitcoms as “situating comedies” that use timing, dialogue, and performance to generate humour from everyday interactions, while Mintz (1985) emphasises the genre's reliance on predictability and character continuity. Central to sitcom humour is conversational interaction. Dynel (2009) defines conversational humour as verbal creativity embedded in dialogue that produces amusement while advancing or momentarily disrupting narrative progression. Such humour often emerges through misunderstanding, exaggeration, wordplay, and social irony.

In Nigerian sitcoms, conversational humour is inseparable from linguistic plurality and cultural specificity. The use of Nigerian Pidgin enables humour that resonates with local audiences through shared linguistic knowledge and lived experience. Parasocial interaction further intensifies audience engagement, as viewers develop emotional familiarity with characters across episodes (Horton & Strauss, 1957; Köhne, 2012). As Esan (1993) argues, sitcoms function not only as entertainment but also as cultural mirrors, reflecting and interrogating social tensions such as class aspiration, gender relations, and moral contradiction. Within this framework, *Jenifa's Diary* exemplifies how language-driven humour operates simultaneously as comic performance and social critique.

Theoretical Framework

This study is anchored in Disparagement Humour Theory (DHT) and Social Identity Theory (SIT) to explain how humour in *Jenifa's Diary* operates simultaneously as a comic strategy and a social process through which identity, power, and belonging are negotiated in Nigerian popular media. Together, these frameworks illuminate both how humour produces laughter and why such laughter carries sociocultural meaning.

Disparagement Humour Theory has its intellectual roots in early philosophical accounts of humour associated with superiority and ridicule, most notably in the work of Thomas Hobbes, who argued that laughter often arises from a sense of sudden superiority over others. This foundational idea was later developed within psychological and media studies by Dolf Zillmann, who conceptualised disparagement humour as a form of comedy that allows ridicule, mockery, or hostility to be expressed within a socially acceptable frame. According to Zillmann, humour provides a protective shield through which critical or aggressive messages can be communicated without provoking overt resistance (as cited in Ferguson & Ford, 2008).

Ferguson and Ford (2008) systematised Disparagement Humour Theory by demonstrating how humour masks criticism through exaggeration, caricature, and ridicule, making negative evaluations appear playful rather than hostile. In this model, disparagement humour positions a target—an individual, social group, or institution—as foolish, inferior, or morally flawed,

enabling audiences to laugh while simultaneously engaging in social judgement. The comic frame reduces psychological discomfort, rendering critique both palatable and pleasurable. However, as Nabi, Moyer-Gusé, and Byrne (2007) argue, this masking effect can also normalise stereotypes and value judgements by diverting critical scrutiny through amusement.

In African and Nigerian contexts, disparagement humour has been shown to function as a subtle mode of social and political commentary. Eesuola (2015) illustrates how exaggeration and ridicule in Fela Kuti's satirical music provoke laughter while simultaneously diluting the urgency of political critique. Similarly, Mendiburo-Seguel et al. (2017) demonstrate that disparagement humour in political communication often transforms dissent into entertainment, fostering cynicism rather than mobilisation. Within Nigerian comedy, ridicule frequently targets ignorance, pretence, corruption, and social deviance, allowing audiences to critique these behaviours indirectly. DHT is therefore particularly suited to analysing *Jenifa's Diary*, where humour consistently emerges from linguistic misuse, exaggeration, and social exposure.

Social Identity Theory, developed by Henri Tajfel and John Turner (1985), complements this perspective by explaining how humour operates within processes of group formation and boundary-making. SIT posits that individuals construct their sense of self through group membership organised around in-group and out-group distinctions. Social identity is shaped through three interrelated processes—social categorisation, social identification, and social comparison—through which individuals seek positive self-concept by favourably distinguishing their in-group from relevant out-groups (Tajfel & Turner, 1985; Branscombe et al., 1999).

Language plays a central role in these identity processes, particularly in multilingual societies. Linguistic choices signal belonging, authority, aspiration, and exclusion, and humour often mobilises these signals. In Nigerian contexts, Uwanamodo (2019) shows how political comedy constructs moral binaries of “us” versus “them,” reinforcing collective identity through ridicule, while Adebisi et al. (2023) argue that humour transforms shared frustration into communal solidarity. In *Jenifa's Diary*, Nigerian Pidgin functions as a powerful identity marker: code choice, accent, and fluency signal class position, educational background, and insider or outsider status, with Jenifa's hybrid speech situating her in a liminal identity space—marginalised within elite contexts yet authentic to many viewers.

Integrated, DHT explains how humour works, while SIT explains why it matters. DHT accounts for the mechanics of ridicule that generate laughter, and SIT accounts for how that laughter reinforces or contests social boundaries. In this study, the two theories guide interpretation without being repeatedly restated in the analysis, allowing theory to illuminate specific linguistic moments while keeping the empirical data at the centre of discussion.

Synopsis of “HIV Status” and “Fake Life”

“HIV Status” centres on Jenifa's collapse from self-medication and her subsequent hospitalisation, where her misunderstanding of medical terminology becomes the primary source of humour. After overhearing a conversation about an HIV-positive individual allegedly infecting others, Jenifa panics and compels her salon staff to undergo compulsory HIV testing. This decision triggers fear, avoidance, and exaggerated reactions among the workers,

particularly Timini, who refuses testing altogether. While most staff members eventually test negative and celebrate, Timini's disappearance leaves the episode unresolved. Through linguistic confusion, exaggerated fear, and Pidgin-mediated interaction, the episode humorously engages issues of health misinformation, HIV stigma, and public anxiety, setting the stage for linguistic and identity-based analysis.

“Fake Life” explores deception, aspiration, and performance in contemporary Lagos. The episode follows James, who believes a social media influencer's invitation for a manicure signals economic breakthrough, only to discover that her online affluence is fabricated. His confrontation exposes the gap between digital self-fashioning and lived reality. In a parallel storyline, Pelumi's attempt to access elite status through a transactional relationship collapses when her deceit is publicly revealed. The episode employs Nigerian Pidgin as the language of exposure and confrontation, using humour to critique influencer culture, material pretence, and aspirational excess.

Analysis and Discussion

In the episode analyses that follow, Disparagement Humour Theory (DHT) and Social Identity Theory (SIT) are not restated at length but are applied interpretively. DHT is deployed to identify moments in which ridicule, exaggeration, and linguistic distortion are framed as entertainment, thereby rendering social critique psychologically acceptable to audiences. SIT, on the other hand, is used to interpret how linguistic choices—particularly the alternation between Nigerian Pidgin English and Standard English—construct in-group and out-group boundaries, signal authority or marginality, and negotiate authenticity within specific social contexts. This approach allows theory to illuminate precise linguistic moments without overshadowing the empirical data.

Focusing on two purposively selected episodes of *Jenifa's Diary*—“HIV Status” (Season 11, Episode 4) and “Fake Life” (Season 21, Episode 1)—this section examines how Nigerian Pidgin English functions as a medium of humour, identity performance, and social commentary. Drawing on DHT and SIT as interpretive frameworks, the analysis explores the linguistic strategies that generate humour, the cultural politics embedded in linguistic performance, and the ways humour engages lived Nigerian sociocultural realities. Collectively, the episodes demonstrate how Funke Akindele's creative manipulation of Pidgin—through malapropism, code-switching, phonological distortion, and embodied performance—produces laughter that is simultaneously pleasurable and reflective, entertaining and critical, mocking yet solidarising.

“HIV Status”

Linguistic Humour: Malapropisms, Misinterpretations, and Phonological Distortions

“HIV Status” exemplifies Funke Akindele's mastery of linguistic humour rooted in malapropism and misinterpretation. In the episode's opening scene at the hospital, Jenifa wakes up disoriented and immediately begins to misinterpret clinical vocabulary. Her confusion becomes the central comic engine. The doctor's instruction that she will be “discharged” is misinterpreted as “discard”, leading her to panic that the hospital intends to throw her away like waste. The correct pronunciation /dɪs'tʃɑ:dʒ/ is re-rendered as /'dɪskɑ:d/, producing an incongruity that aligns with classical humour theory. The humour arises partly from semantic proximity—both words begin with the same phonological root—yet diverge sharply in

meaning. Under DHT, this ridicule of linguistic confusion becomes socially acceptable because it is framed as comedy; the aggression inherent in laughing at someone's misunderstanding is masked by the comedic scenario.

Jenifa continues this comedic pattern with other medical terms. She renders “diagnose” (/ˈdaɪ.əɡ.nəʊz/) as “dagnose” (/dag.noz/), and “self-medication” (/self ˌmedɪˈkeɪʃən/) as “self-edisation” (/self ɛdɪˈzeɪʃən/). These distortions are not random; they reflect a common sociolinguistic reality where many Nigerians navigate medical encounters using approximation, improvisation, and guesswork. Consequently, the humour resonates because viewers recognise the linguistic struggle. SIT helps explain this relatability: those who have wrestled with intimidating medical English find solidarity in the exaggerated representation.

The phonological humour is enriched by gestures and physical performance. Jenifa's frantic search for her wig, her exaggeration of fear, and her wide-eyed protest—“Make dem discard me?”—add layers of slapstick that fuse with linguistic humour to heighten the comic effect. Her body becomes as expressive as her speech; movement, posture, and facial exaggeration transform malapropism into embodied performance.

The episode constructs humour, then, through a fusion of linguistic distortion and performative excess. But these errors also function as markers of class and educational inequality. The medical environment becomes a stage where Jenifa's unfamiliarity with biomedical discourse exposes her socio-economic positioning. Although viewers laugh, the scene gestures toward a deeper problem of health literacy in Nigeria, where specialised vocabulary often alienates ordinary patients.

Identity Performance Through Pidgin: Class Positioning, Group Belonging, and Authority

The interplay between language and identity forms another layer of humour in “HIV Status.” Within the hospital, Jenifa's Pidgin positions her as an outsider. Her hybridised register—half desperate English, half indignant Pidgin—repeatedly clashes with the formal medical environment. Yet when she returns to her salon, the same register functions as a badge of authority. This shift illustrates how identity is context-dependent and linguistically constructed.

At the salon, Jenifa transforms from confused patient to assertive leader. Her announcement—“All of una must follow me go hospital tomorrow for HIV test. That's my memo”—utilises Pidgin not as a sign of ignorance but as a managerial tool. The linguistic mixture of mock-formality (“memo”) with everyday Pidgin mirrors workplace hierarchies in many Nigerian informal-sector businesses, where English is reserved for external performance, while Pidgin is the internal language of coordination. Under SIT, this shift shows how language marks group boundaries. In the hospital, English is the “ingroup” code; in the salon, Pidgin becomes the dominant identity marker.

The staff's reactions further illuminate language's identity functions. James and Sam's exaggerated panic—expressed through rapid-fire Pidgin—reveals how the language conveys fear with immediacy. Timini, the youngest, embodies youth anxiety as he flees the hospital entirely. The humour relies on performative escalation, but the linguistic choices underscore generational and class dynamics: these characters are comfortable expressing vulnerability only

in Pidgin.

Conversely, the doctor's English signifies medical authority, formality, and detachment. This linguistic contrast situates English as aspirational yet alienating, while Pidgin is communal, affective, and intimate. Through its portrayal of Jenifa's dual identities, the episode demonstrates how Pidgin mediates belonging and exclusion across social contexts.

Social Commentary: Health Misinformation, HIV Stigma, and Panic Culture

Although humorous, "HIV Status" performs vital social commentary on health literacy and stigma. Jenifa's panic illustrates the pervasive fear of HIV testing in Nigeria—a fear often rooted in misinformation and shame. Her confusion over medical terms mirrors a broader societal challenge: medical English is frequently unintelligible to everyday Nigerians, contributing to misunderstanding and avoidance.

The overheard conversation about an HIV-positive colleague allegedly infecting multiple partners triggers collective panic, reflecting the power of gossip as informal public-health communication. This dramatization exposes how rumours often spread faster than accurate medical information, shaping social behaviours in disproportionate ways.

Yet the narrative gradually shifts from panic to empowerment. Despite her linguistic distortions and exaggerated fears, Jenifa mobilises her staff toward responsible health behaviour. Her insistence on testing—delivered entirely in Pidgin—translates institutional health advice into culturally accessible language. When staff members later celebrate their negative results with jubilation, the episode normalises testing and dislodges stigma through humour.

The final scene involving Timini's fear dramatizes the psychology of avoidance. His flight from the hospital is comic, but symbolises the real dilemma many Nigerians face: the tension between wanting reassurance and fearing the consequences of knowledge. Humour softens this confrontation, allowing viewers to laugh at their anxieties while reflecting on the need for proactive health management.

In sum, "HIV Status" uses Pidgin-based humour to expose vulnerabilities in health communication while modelling culturally resonant strategies for overcoming fear and misinformation—transforming comedy into public pedagogy.

"Fake Life"

Pidgin, Slang, and Lagos Aspirational Culture

"Fake Life" translates the linguistic creativity of Pidgin into commentary on contemporary Lagos materialism and digital culture. The episode revolves around characters who curate exaggerated lifestyles to project success, particularly on social media. Pidgin becomes the expressive medium that captures the contradictions of urban aspiration.

James exemplifies this dynamic. Living precariously and recently replaced at the salon, he clings to a fantasy of upward mobility. When the influencer "Boneless Sparkles" contacts him for a manicure, he declares triumphantly, "Finally I don hammer!"—a Pidgin slang expression meaning sudden economic breakthrough. His expectation is linguistically coded through

Pidgin's optimistic futurity, a register often employed to articulate hope amid harsh realities.

The humour intensifies when James arrives at the influencer's home and discovers that her digital display of affluence is entirely performative. The contrast between her online lifestyle and physical living conditions becomes the episode's central comedic incongruity. His outburst—"You dey live fake life! You go dey pose with big car but your house no fine!"—translates moral outrage into Pidgin's blunt directness. Unlike English, which might soften the reproach, Pidgin conveys unfiltered truth, becoming a linguistic scalpel that cuts through digital illusions.

This scene also reveals Pidgin's capacity to articulate class-based frustration. James's disillusionment reflects the exhaustion of Nigeria's gig economy, where workers constantly negotiate dignity and survival. Pidgin foregrounds this reality by grounding class discourse in everyday urban speech.

Disparagement Humour, Exposure, and Social Correction

The episode's humour arises from cycles of deception and exposure. According to DHT, disparagement humour becomes socially palatable because the comedic frame masks aggression. In "Fake Life," this mechanism allows viewers to laugh at characters' failures, pretence, and humiliation without discomfort.

The influencer's duplicity is treated humorously, turning her into the object of ridicule. Her inability to pay James sparks a comedic confrontation that escalates into physical tussle. Although humorous, this ridicule functions as social correction. The show critiques the moral inconsistencies of influencer culture: the pressure to perform wealth, the emptiness of digital validation, and the detachment between online personas and offline realities.

Pelumi's storyline amplifies this critique. Her attempt to impress a wealthy benefactor by manipulating his driver ends in spectacular failure. When the Chief's wife catches her with his car and delivers a public beating, the scene blends slapstick with moral exposure. Pelumi's humiliation is comedic, but also emblematic of the dangers of transactional relationships and aspirational deceit.

Thus, while "HIV Status" generates humour through misunderstanding, "Fake Life" generates humour through exposure. The latter's ridicule projects outward—toward pretence and hypocrisy—making humour a corrective mechanism. Pidgin becomes the language of confrontation, calling out deception in words that resonate with ordinary audiences.

Class, Code-Switching, and the Politics of Identity Performance

Code-switching plays a crucial role in how characters negotiate status and aspiration. In Jenifa's Diary, English is associated with sophistication, professionalism, and upward mobility. Characters often deploy English when they wish to appear elite or polished, especially in public-facing environments such as Instagram. Conversely, under emotional stress or when exposed, these same characters revert to Pidgin, the language of authenticity.

This oscillation captures the politics of identity performance in Lagos. For the influencer, English captions and curated photos signal elite belonging. For Pelumi, English becomes the

mask of legitimacy she uses during her interactions with the Chief. Yet when conflict arises, both characters revert to Pidgin—the language of “true self”—revealing vulnerability, anger, or desperation.

SIT illuminates this duality. Pidgin signifies in-group belonging; English marks out-group aspiration. Characters drift between these linguistic identities in response to context, power, and emotional state. This dynamic situates Pidgin not as “broken English,” but as the linguistic core of everyday Nigerian identity—a code that reveals truth even when English attempts to conceal it.

Comparative Discussion and Synthesis

A comparative reading of “HIV Status” and “Fake Life” demonstrates that while both episodes rely on Nigerian Pidgin as a humour-generating resource, they mobilise it in distinct sociocultural registers. In “HIV Status,” humour emerges from linguistic misunderstanding and fear, with malapropisms and semantic distortions mediating health anxiety and stigma. In contrast, “Fake Life” derives humour from exposure and moral correction, using Pidgin as the language of confrontation that punctures aspirational performance and digital deception. Across both episodes, Pidgin functions as a marker of authenticity and emotional truth, contrasting with English as a language of aspiration and institutional authority. These differences reveal Nigerian Pidgin's flexibility as a comic code capable of articulating both vulnerability and critique, thereby reinforcing its centrality to identity negotiation in Nigerian popular media.

Conclusion

This study has examined Nigerian Pidgin English as a central mechanism through which humour, identity, and social commentary are produced in *Jenifa's Diary*. Focusing on “HIV Status” and “Fake Life,” the analysis demonstrates that Pidgin is not merely a stylistic embellishment but a culturally grounded linguistic system that structures comic meaning and mediates audience engagement. While “HIV Status” employs linguistic misunderstanding to address health anxiety and stigma, “Fake Life” uses exposure-based humour to critique aspirational culture and digital performance.

Through Disparagement Humour Theory and Social Identity Theory, the study shows that humour in the series simultaneously entertains and negotiates class, authority, and belonging. By foregrounding Nigerian Pidgin as the primary humour engine of the sitcom, the study contributes to sociolinguistics, media studies, and humour scholarship, and opens pathways for future research on audience reception and comparative Nigerian television comedy.

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